MOREH NEVUCHIM

# What Are Demons? Gender in Torah, Adam & the Shedim

**Given Tuesday 16 June 2026** · Moreh Nevuchim §1 · Ch 6–7

**Sefer:** Moreh Nebuchim (The Guide for the Perplexed) — Rambam **Section:** 1 · Chapter 6 (completed) & Chapter 7 **Topic:** Ish & Isha — Is God Male or Female? · Yalad and the Power of a Teacher · Shedim Reinterpreted **Text:** Sefaria edition (Rabbi Chaim Makbili's modern Hebrew translation from the Arabic)

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## Recap — The Arc of Section 1 So Far

| Chapters | Theme |
|---|---|
| **1–2** | Tzelem Elokim; Adam before and after the sin (emet/sheker → tov/ra) |
| **3** | *Temunah* vs. *Tavnit* — images of God |
| **4** | The verbs of seeing God — sight vs. insight |
| **5** | Caution in ascending to the divine; the burning bush (four readings); Moshe vs. the nobles |
| **6 (begun last week)** | *Ish* & *Isha* — terms borrowed for male/female creatures, then for anything that attaches/receives. **Ish = Tzura (form); Isha = Chomer (matter).** All existence is the union of form and matter |

### Recap of Chapter 6's Core (Last Week)

- *Ish/Isha* primarily = human male/female; borrowed for animals (איש ואשתו ... מכל הבהמה = simply male and female); then *isha* borrowed for **anything designated to attach/receive** (the Mishkan curtains: חוברות אשה אל אחותה)
- **Ish = Tzura (form, the affector/mashpia); Isha = Chomer (matter, the affected/nishpa)**
- Per Yesodei HaTorah: nothing exists as form-alone or matter-alone — all existence is their union
  the woman as receptacle/manifester of the man — לזאת יקרא אשה כי מאיש לוקחה
- Implications: equal but different (egalitarianism-as-sameness is un-Torah); marriage as completion (לבשר אחד; one without a spouse lacks *shalom* = *shleimut*, completeness)

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## PART 1 — Completing Chapter 6: Is God Male or Female?

## The Verse — "Hashem Ish Milchamah"

**ה' איש מלחמה, ה' שמו** "*Hashem is a man of war, Hashem is His name*" (Shirat HaYam)

Obviously not a physical man. So what does it mean that Hashem is a "man of war"?

### Why God Is Usually Referred to in the Masculine

Hakadosh Baruch Hu is **primarily the משפיע (affector/influencer/giver)**, rather than the affected.

That is why Hashem is normally referred to in the **masculine** — He is the mashpia, the affector.

### What About the Feminine References to God?

We Sefardim say **נקדישך ונעריצך** (feminine: "we will sanctify You"); many liturgical references are feminine. Does this mean Hashem is affected by us?

**Absolutely not.** Anything that is *affected* is *incomplete* — which would contradict God being *shalem* (complete and unchanging).

When we refer to Hashem in the feminine, we are NOT referring to God Himself, but to **a manifestation** — the **Shechinah**, etc. God Himself is never feminine, because He cannot be affected.

**In essence, God is neither masculine nor feminine** — but insofar as we assign Him a gender, it is masculine, because He is primarily the affector.

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## The Kli Yakar (Rabbi Shlomo Laniado, ~500 years ago)

*(Brought via Rabbi Daniel Korobkin's Moreh shiurim.)*

On the last verse of Bereishit Chapter 1 — and the question: **Why do we begin Friday-night Kiddush with "Yom HaShishi" before "Vayechulu"?**

### The Hidden Name

The phrase **יום הששי ויכלו השמים** — the final letters spell:

**יום הששִׁי** ויכלו **ה**שמים → **י-ה-ו-ה** (the four-letter Name)

וכפי הפשט חתם על מעשה בראשית בשם של י-ה המשותף בין איש לאשה *"He sealed the creation with the Name Y-H, which is shared between ish and isha".*

### The Yud and the Hei

The Gemara (Bava Batra): everything Hashem created is male or female (זכר ונקבה בראם). Hence Hebrew — unlike English — assigns gender to everything, even inanimate objects.

| Letter | Gender | In the words | Names of God |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Yud (י)** | **Masculine** — the affector | (Aleph-Yud-Shin) **אִישׁ** carries the **Yud** | Masculine Names begin with **Aleph** (the beginning/affector): Adon-ai, Elok-im, Kel |
| **Hei (ה)** | **Feminine** — the affected | (Aleph-Shin-Hei) **אִשָּׁה** carries the **Hei** | Feminine Names (Shechinah, Shakkai, Shabbat) relate to the end of the alphabet (the Shin/affected) |

*(This is Rabbi Tatz's framework: Yud = masculine, Hei = feminine.)*

### The Kli Yakar's Point

כי כל זכר דמיון למשפיע, וכל נקבה דמיון למושפע *"Every male resembles the affector; every female resembles the affected".*

Everything in the universe contains an affecting side and an affected side. In the creation of a child: the man gives the *zera* (the tzura — the conceptual/theoretical), and the woman **receives** it and over nine months

develops the *chomer* (the matter).

**הקדוש ברוך הוא המשפיע הראשון... אבל הוא יתברך אינו מושפע מזולתו** *"Hashem is the first affector... but He Himself is never affected by another."*

**The Kli Yakar holds God is innately masculine** — always referred to as "He" — because He is the eternal mashpia, never affected. (Feminine references = manifestations like the Shechinah, not God Himself.)

**The master point: the universe is binary — male or female, affector or affected. There is no non-binary.** This is why creation is "sealed" with Y-H: existence is *complete* only when it is both male and female. (The Vav-Hei of the Name, the Kli Yakar adds, relate to the future/Olam Haba — beyond our scope here.)

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## Closing Chapter 6 — Ach and Achot Too

הרי התבאר לך שגם **אחות ואח** הם רב-משמעיים על דרך ההשאלה כמו איש ואשה *Brother and sister are likewise multi-meaning, borrowed terms.*

- **Achot** — from the Mishkan curtains (חוברות אשה אל אחותה — "each to her sister")
- **Ach** — likely from the Keruvim: **ופניהם איש אל אחיו** ("their faces, each man to his brother") — denoting their character as *mashpiim* (affectors), facing one another

Just as *ish/isha* are metaphorical and multi-meaning, so are *ach/achot*.

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## Why Is This Chapter Here? (The Placement Question)

The first five chapters dealt with **incorporeality**. Chapter 6 seems to digress. Why?

### The Narboni's Answer

It continues the incorporeality theme **because of ה' איש מלחמה** — Rambam wants to clarify that "man of war" doesn't mean God is a male, but that He is the **mashpia (affector)** — a borrowed term, not an anthropomorphism.

### The Simpler/Preferred Answer

Rambam told us in his introduction he would also explain **Ma'aseh Bereshit** (the workings of creation/physics). Just as Chapters 1–2 covered both incorporeality *and* the creation narrative (Adam's sin), **ish and isha are central to the creation narrative** — what marriage is, the binary structure of existence. This is Ma'aseh Bereshit: understanding the physics of the world Hashem created.

### Chapter 6 Summary

*Ish/Isha* are borrowed for male/female creatures and, crucially, for **anything that attaches** — *ish* the affector, *isha* the receptacle. All existence reduces to ish/isha = tzura/chomer. From this: the bond of marriage, the binary universe, why God is usually masculine (the affector), and that *ach/achot* are likewise metaphorical terms.

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## PART 2 — Chapter 7: Yalad, the Power of a Teacher, and Shedim

This chapter continues from Chapter 6: a man and woman unite — **what is the product?** And it ties directly into Rambam's halachic works.

## The Five Meanings of יָלַד (Yalad — "to give birth")

| # | Meaning | Proof Text |
|---|---|---|
| 1 | **Literal birth** — offspring of man and woman | וילדו לו בנים (Ki Tetzei) |
| 2 | **Creation of natural phenomena** | בטרם הרים יולדו — "before the mountains were born" (Tehillim) |
| 3 | **The earth sprouting** (rain causing growth) | הגשם... הולידה והצמיחה — rain "gave birth to" the earth (Yeshayahu) |
| 4 | **New events occurring** | כי לא תדע מה ילד יום — "you don't know what the day will birth" (Mishlei) |
| 5 | **Birthing new ideas / views — being taught** | יחבל און... וילד שקר — conceiving and "birthing" falsehood (Tehillim); ובילדי נכרים יספיקו — adopting the ideas of the nations (Yeshayahu, per Yonatan ben Uziel) |

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## The Power of a Teacher — Meaning 5 in Depth

**מי שלימד אדם דבר מה והקנה לו דעה, הוא כאילו הוליד את האיש ההוא — One who teaches a person and imparts knowledge to him — it is as if he gave birth to that person.**

This is why the disciples of prophets are called **בני הנביאים** (the "sons of the prophets") — not biological sons, but students.

### The Gemara (Sanhedrin 19b)

כל המלמד את בן חברו תורה, מעלה עליו הכתוב כאילו ילדו — *One who teaches another's child Torah — Scripture credits him as if he birthed the child.*

**Proof:** Bamidbar opens **ואלה תולדות אהרן ומשה** ("these are the offspring of Aharon and Moshe") — yet then lists only **the sons of Aharon** (Nadav, Avihu, Elazar, Itamar). Why are they called Moshe's offspring too?

אהרן ילד, ומשה לימד — לפיכך נקראו על שמו — *Aharon birthed them; Moshe taught them — therefore they bear his name too.*

### Illuminating the Verse in Toldot

**ואלה תולדות יצחק בן אברהם — אברהם הוליד את יצחק**

The apparent redundancy is resolved: Yitzchak was Avraham's son **both physically and intellectually** — Avraham birthed him *and* taught him his Torah and worldview.

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## The Halachic Payoff — Saving Your Teacher Before Your Parent

The Mishnah (end of Bava Metzia Ch. 2): if your **parent** and your **rav** are both drowning and you can save only one — **you save your rav first.**

### The Qualification (Gemara)

This applies only to your **rabo muvhak** — your primary teacher from whom you learned **the majority** of your Torah and intellect. *(Rare today: in earlier times one teacher took a student from alef-bet all the way up. Now we pass through many teachers, so a true rabo muvhak is uncommon.)*

### Why This Makes Sense (via the Rambam)

A **rabo muvhak gave birth to you** — just as your parent did. Your parent birthed you into a life of 120 years; your teacher birthed you into **Olam Haba — infinite time.** So the teacher's "birthing" has the longer-lasting effect.

### The Further Halacha

If your **father** also taught you Torah (even not the majority), you save **him** first — because he birthed you *both physically and (partly) spiritually*. Only when the father taught little, and the rabo muvhak gave you the majority of your Torah, do you save the rav first.

This is also the foundation of the *premium on kavod* for teachers and elders (מפני שיבה תקום והדרת פני זקן; אפילו לימדו אות אחת חייב לכבדו) — they are, in a sense, one's parents.

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## The Cryptic Cross-Reference — "When We Discuss *Ben*"

Rambam says he'll explain more "when we discuss the term *ben* (son)" — but **he never does** (Rav Kapach notes this).

### Rav Makbili's Beautiful Suggestion

Notice: for *literal* birth (meaning 1), Rambam cited a late verse (Ki Tetzei: וילדו לו בנים) — skipping the obvious earlier one in the creation narrative itself:

**בעצב תלדי בנים** *"In pain you shall bear children"* (Bereishit 3, the consequence to Chava)

Why skip it? **Deliberately** — so that we connect the dots ourselves: *be'etzev teldi banim* is not only a curse but a **reality** — that with hard work (etzev), one can "birth" ideas and concepts in those who come after, and they become one's *banim*. Through toil, a person births many "children" far beyond biological offspring — by teaching.

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## The Climax — Adam, Shet, and the Meaning of Shedim

### The Verse

**ויחי אדם שלושים ומאת שנה, ויולד בדמותו כצלמו, ויקרא את שמו שת** *Adam lived 130 years, and birthed in his likeness and image, and called him Shet.*

### Rambam's Reading

For Adam's first 130 years (after the sin), his children **did not attain the true human form** — they lacked the full **tzelem and demut** (the intellectual form, per Chapters 1–2). Only **Shet** — whom Adam **taught and gave understanding** — attained human completeness. Hence specifically of Shet: *birthed in his likeness and image.*

- Adam needed 130 years to do **teshuvah** and develop himself enough to transmit *tzelem Elokim* properly to a descendant

- **Shet** = from *yashat/shitah* — **foundation**; he is the next *foundation* of the world after Adam and Chava, because the world is founded on those with correct intellect *(Rav Nebenzahl)*
- *(Rabbi Korobkin suggests this could even engage the evolution question — the pre-Shet "incomplete humans" as a separate matter; a discussion for elsewhere.)*

### The Final Paragraph — Worse Than an Animal

One who has not attained **כל מי שלא השיג אותה הצורה... אינו אדם, אלא בעל חיים בעל תבנית אדם ותארו** that [intellectual] form **is not a human — but an animal in the figure (tavnit) of a human.**

And in fact **worse than an animal**:

Because the intellect כי כוח המחשבה ושיקול הדעת... משתמש בהם לצורך תחבולות הגורמות לרעות ולנזקים meant for perfection is used instead **for schemes that cause harm** — a capacity no animal has.

*He is like something resembling a human, imitating one* — not והרי הוא **כדבר הדומה לאדם המחקה אותו** truly human.

This explains human criminality and immorality, which we don't find among animals: humans can turn their intellect to destructive ends.

### The Gemara (Eruvin 18b) — Reinterpreted

*All the years Adam was "excommunicated,"* כל אותן השנים שהיה אדם הראשון בנידוי, הוליד רוחין ושדין ולילין *he birthed spirits, demons, and lilin.*

The Gemara clarifies: during 130 years Adam separated from his wife (a chasid doing teshuvah) — so the "births" were from nocturnal emissions.

### Rambam's Figurative Reading — What a Shed Actually Is

**Rambam reads this entire Gemara as a metaphor** *(against the Kabbalistic literal reading)*:

A **shed (demon) is not a spiritual entity coming to get you.** It is a **sub-human** — a person with the physical figure of a human but undeveloped or corrupted intellect.

For 130 years Adam birthed **sub-humans** — creatures with eyes, mouth, arms, legs, but without realized *tzelem Elokim*. That is what "ruchin, shedin, lilin" means. Only at 130, after true teshuvah, did he birth **Shet** — *bidmuto ketzalmo*.

### The Narboni's Sharp Point

Many religious people spend their lives on segulot and incantations to ward off **imperceptible** shedim — and thereby **turn their attention away from the real shedim**: the human beings around us with corrupt characters and bad influence. *Those* are the demons to avoid.

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## The Sweep of Supporting Sources — Rambam's Consistent Reinterpretation

### The Metzora Sits Shiva for Himself (Rav David Fohrman)

The leper is cast out, grows hair, tears clothes, conveys tumah almost like a corpse. Why? When a person dies, the family mourns a vacuum. **The metzora mourns himself** — still physically alive and human in body, but having lost his *tzelem Elokim*, become animal-like. He sits shiva for himself.

### "Cursed Is He Who Lies With an Animal" (Pesachim)

ארור שוכב עם כל בהמה — said of one who marries the daughter of an *am ha'aretz*

Not a mere ignoramus — but one who **misused their intellect** and became sub-human (no *tzelem u'demut*). Hence the comparison to an animal.

### Min = A New Species (Rav Moshe Shapiro)

We call heretics **minim** — *species* — because such a person is a **new kind of creature**: not human (no tzelem u'demut), yet not a four-legged beast. A human figure that is, in truth, an animal — a new *min*.

### Capital Punishment Is Not "Murder"

Once Beit Din issues a guilty verdict deserving capital punishment, the person is **no longer classified with the status of a human** — so executing him is not *Lo Tirtzach*; it is not killing a human.

### Rambam on Bava Kamma (Commentary on the Mishnah)

On **שור של ישראל שנגח שור של נכרי — פטור** (a Jew's ox that gores a non-Jew's ox is exempt), Rambam (in his 20s) preempts the moral concern:

> מי שאין בו שלמות המידות האנושיות... אינו בכלל האדם על האמת **".truly included in "human**

Here *Yisrael* = one who developed character and bears *tzelem u'demut*; *nochri* = one who did not — a **sub-human**. The exemption is because it's not goring between two full humans. *(Maor's question — is this like Ir Nidachat? Yes — and there one must say that living among a majority so corrupt, one is inevitably influenced, so the whole city bears a degree of that sub-humanity.)*

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## Rambam's Pattern Across His Writings — Shedim Are Not Literal

| Source | The Gemara | Rambam's Reading |
|---|---|---|
| **Makkot** | Hatra'ah valid even **על ידי עד שד** ("from a demon") | Not a demon — being warned **without seeing** the warner (e.g., hearing a voice from the other side of a building); a human then testifies to it. *(Tosafot, by contrast, takes "shed" literally and constructs an okimta.)* |
| **Shabbat (Bameh Madlikin)** | Extinguishing a candle **מפני רוח רעה** | *Ruach ra'ah* = **melancholy/depression** (he writes "melancholy" in the Commentary) — the person needs to sleep and can't with the light on |
| **Gittin/Yevamot (agunah)** | Testimony of a death valid only if you saw the speaker or his shadow (**בבואה דבבואה**) — lest it be a **shed** | Rambam **omits this qualification entirely** when codifying — because he didn't accept the concept of shedim |
| **Snakebite on Shabbat** | One may recite an **incantation** (lachash) on a wound | Rambam: it **doesn't work** — permitted only **psychologically**, to prevent the sufferer's distress |

Rambam consistently reinterprets shedim, incantations, and amulets figuratively or psychologically.

### The Vilna Gaon's Sharp Objection

The Gra was famously upset with the Rambam here. On Rambam's statement that **כשפים, שמות, לחשים, שדים, וקמיעות — הכל הוא שקר** ("witchcraft, names, incantations, demons, and amulets are all false"):

כבר הכו על קדקדו, שמצינו הרבה מעשה בגמרא [בכשפים]... ופילוסופיה הטתו... לפרש הגמרא בדרך הליצה ולעקרם מפשטם — *The Gra: it was his philosophical leanings that bent him to explain these Gemarot metaphorically and uproot them from their plain meaning.* וחס ושלום, איני מאמין בהם ולא מהם ולא מהמונם אלא כל הדברים כפשטם, ויש להם פנימיות" — *God forbid — I do not [side] with them; rather all these things are literal, and they have an inner meaning"* — not the philosophers' meaning.

So the Gra holds shedim, amulets, and incantations are **literal** (with a deeper layer); Rambam reads them figuratively. *(Some suggest Rambam had a different girsa — but the pattern is clearly deliberate.)*

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## Tonight's Summary

## Chapter 6 (Completed) — Is God Male or Female?

- *Ish milchamah* — God is "masculine" only in the sense of being the **mashpia (affector)**; feminine references point to **manifestations** (Shechinah), never God Himself, who cannot be affected
- **Kli Yakar**: Kiddush's *Yom HaShishi Vayechulu* encodes the Name Y-H-W-H; **Yud = masculine, Hei = feminine**; the universe is **binary** — sealed as "male and female He created them"
- *Ach/Achot* are likewise metaphorical (Keruvim; Mishkan curtains)
- Placement: this is **Ma'aseh Bereshit** — the physics of creation

## Chapter 7 — Yalad, Teachers, and Shedim

- **Yalad** = (1) birth, (2) creation of nature, (3) earth sprouting, (4) new events, (5) **birthing ideas — teaching**
- **To teach someone is to give birth to them** (בני הנביאים; Aharon birthed, Moshe taught; אברהם הוליד את יצחק) — grounding the halacha to **save your rabo muvhak before your parent** (he birthed you into infinite time)
- *Be'etzev teldi banim* (cryptic) — with toil, one births "children" through teaching
- **Adam & Shet**: for 130 years Adam birthed sub-humans; only after teshuvah did he birth Shet *bidmuto ketzalmo* — the new **foundation**
- **A shed is a sub-human** — a person in human figure lacking realized *tzelem Elokim*; can be *worse* than an animal by misusing intellect
- The real demons are corrupt people around us (Narboni) — not imperceptible spirits
- Supporting reinterpretations: the metzora mourning himself; *min* = a new species; capital punishment not "murder"; the Bava Kamma ox; and across Makkot, Shabbat, Gittin, snakebite — **Rambam reads shedim/incantations figuratively**, against which the **Vilna Gaon** strongly objected

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## Coming Up Next

Continuing the Moreh — the next chapters of Section 1.

*(Chodesh Tov — Rosh Chodesh Tammuz.)*

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*B'Ezrat Hashem*

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